friends. In the Chief's Lounge, all the PSOs and their wives were waiting for us and we had a cup of tea together. After thanking them all and bidding them farewell, I made my way to my Office. For a change, there were no files to be seen, except for one folder placed in the centre of the desk. Gen Manoj Pande and his wife, Archana, entered and we had a small photo session. At the stroke of noon, we signed on the dotted line, and I handed over the Chief's Baton to Gen Manoj Pande. It was his Army now, and I could not have handed over to a better person. Veena and I spent a few more minutes with the Chief and his wife, to allow our staff to move out. And then it was down the corridor and out of the South Block. Getting into the car, we drove away, never to look back.

Prior to my retirement, I had conveyed to all media persons that I would be going into a self-imposed *maun vrat*, a sabbatical for six months. A few journalists did contact me once or twice, especially when the Agnipath Scheme was announced, but I conveyed my regrets and they too respected my wishes. I used the time to complete the thesis of my PhD for which I had enrolled way back in 2016, and which had been stuttering along. In June this year (2023), I was finally awarded my doctorate for my work on 'Harmonizing Naga Customs, Traditions and Institutions in the Context of Peace and Development'. I can now add a 'Dr' to my name. If there is one thing I realized during the course of my research, it is that Diversity, Inclusivity and Equality (DIE) is the only way forward to realize our full potential as a nation. The moment any group or community feels victimized or marginalized, it sows the seeds of discord for future conflict and exposes fault lines that can be exploited by those who want to dismember us. These groups too must be equally responsible and abide by the Constitution of India, and not take the law into their own hands. Our diversity should be

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